

Βαρνάβα Ἐπιστολή

The Letter of Barnabas and Early Christian Greek

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Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Κοινή Χριστιανική [Christian Koine](#)
Domain: Θεολογία [Theology](#)
Format: Ἐπιστολή [Epistle](#)

The Epistle of Barnabas is an early Christian text written in Greek, most likely in the late first or early second century CE. Its author is unknown. Although the work is presented as being written by Barnabas, the companion of the Apostle Paul, modern scholars agree this was a common literary device of the time, and the true author remains anonymous.

The date is uncertain, but internal references suggest it was composed after the destruction of the Jerusalem Temple in 70 CE. Many scholars propose Alexandria, Egypt, as its place of origin. The text is a single surviving letter, or epistle, preserved in full in major early manuscripts like the fourth-century Codex Sinaiticus. It was highly regarded in some early Christian circles and was even considered scriptural by influential theologians in Alexandria.

The letter's primary historical importance lies in its sharp theological perspective. It illustrates the growing separation between early Christian communities and Jewish tradition. The author, writing for a Gentile Christian audience, argues that Jewish people had fundamentally misunderstood their own scriptures. According to the author's interpretation, the laws and rituals of the Old Testament were never meant to be followed literally. Instead, they are presented as purely allegorical symbols pointing to the coming of Jesus Christ and the practices of the Christian church. This approach significantly contributed to early debates about the Christian relationship to Jewish scripture and helped shape methods of allegorical biblical interpretation.

Works (1)

- Βαρνάβα ἐπιστολή · [Letter of Barnabas](#) · 193 passages